



◀ Building planes

Women install fixtures and assemblies to the tail fuselage section of a B-17F bomber (a "Flying Fortress") in Long Beach, California, in 1942.

from 1939, it was compulsory for women to serve in the Reich Labor Service (working in agriculture) and in January 1943, worker shortages forced Adolf Hitler to demand all German women aged from 17 to 45 register for employment. Similarly, in Japan, women were initially discouraged from working in industry, but by 1943 so many men had been lost to military service that a women's labor corps was formed. By the next year it had recruited four million Japanese women.

During the war, millions of men and women were coerced into forced labor. Inmates of German concentration camps

performed gruelling physical work; some were contracted out to work for private companies. The Nazis deported millions of people from Central and Eastern Europe for use as slave labor; *Ostarbeiter* (workers from the East) toiled in factories and labor camps, often on starvation rations. In addition, Germany and Japan each took thousands of women from occupied territories to use as sex slaves ("comfort women") in military brothels. Japan is now working on an agreement to pay reparations for its capture of South Korean women during wartime.

An estimated
90%
of Japan's
"comfort women"
did not survive
the war